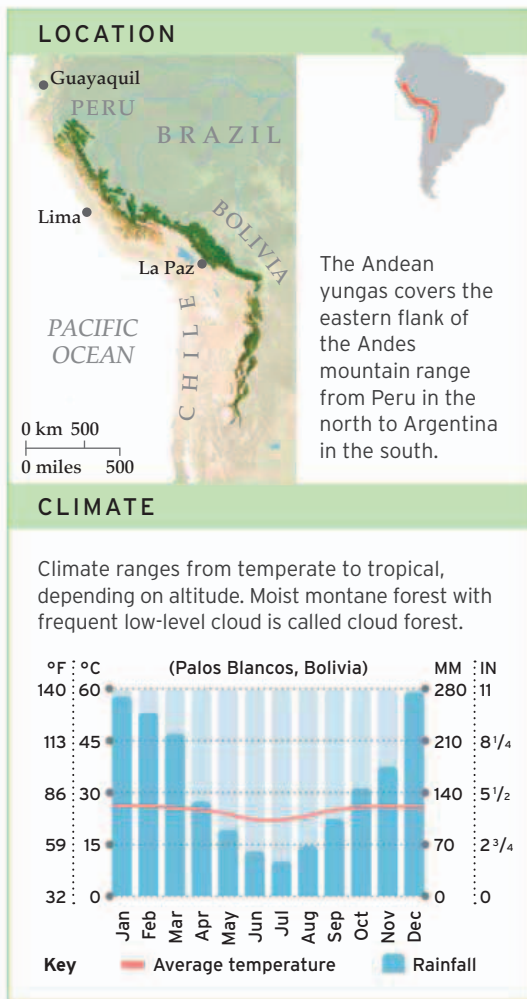




Mountain tapir

Tapirus pinchaque

short, extensible trunk



The mountain tapir is the smallest, most endangered of all four tapir species—fewer than 2,500 are thought to survive in the wild. It makes its home high in the Andes, where its fur, which grows to 2 in (5 cm) thick, has earned it the nickname “woolly tapir.”

Snorkeling for safety

Short, stocky legs and splayed toes make the mountain tapir sure-footed and agile, capable of negotiating steep slopes and dense undergrowth. Like other tapirs, it hides in thickets by day, feeding mainly at dawn and dusk. It has a keen sense of hearing and smell, and flees when threatened, often hiding underwater and using its trunk like a snorkel to breathe until danger passes. Tapirs call to each other with shrill, high-pitched whistles that are often mistaken for birdsong.

- ↔ 6–7 ft (1.8–2.1 m)
- ⚖ 330–440 lb (150–200 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🌿 Leaves, herbs, grasses, fruit



◁ LONG STRIPES

Young tapirs are often called “watermelons on legs” due to their camouflage markings, which allow them to blend in with dappled sunlight.



▷ GRIPPING SNOUT

The mountain tapir feeds using its flexible nose to grasp vegetation, dispersing up to 86 species of plant seeds in the process of eating and digestion.

